



The New Direct Reports

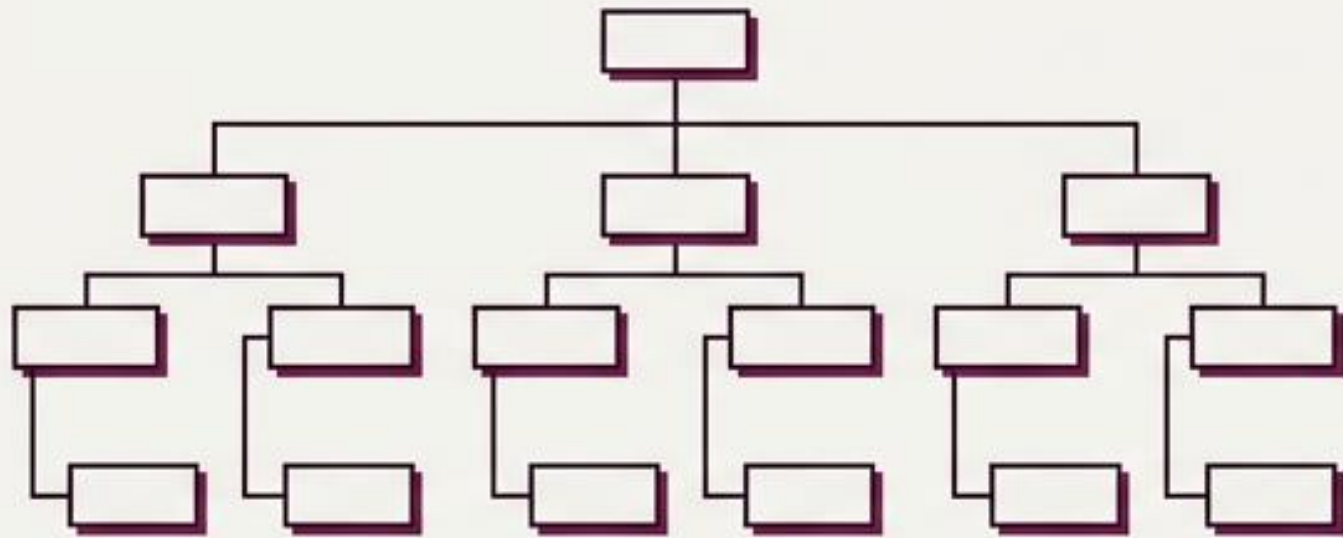
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AI Manager's Playbook
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A 2026 framework for developers and engineering leaders: Why the skills used to lead human teams are the exact skills required to orchestrate AI agents.

By Quan Nguyen, *Skill-Wanderer*

The daily mechanics of software development **haven't changed. The team composition has.**

2024: The Human Team

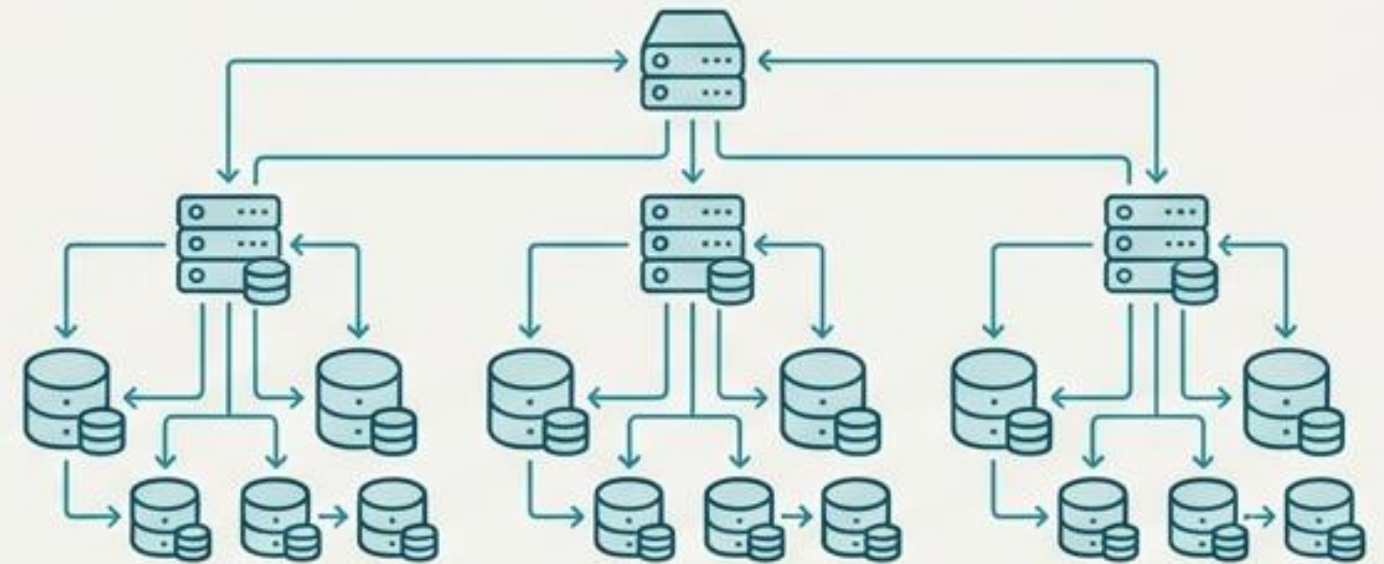


reports: 20

roles: devs, BAs, testers, PM

Past the point of holding everything in your head. Silence is cheap. Confident wrongness is expensive.

2026: The Agent Team

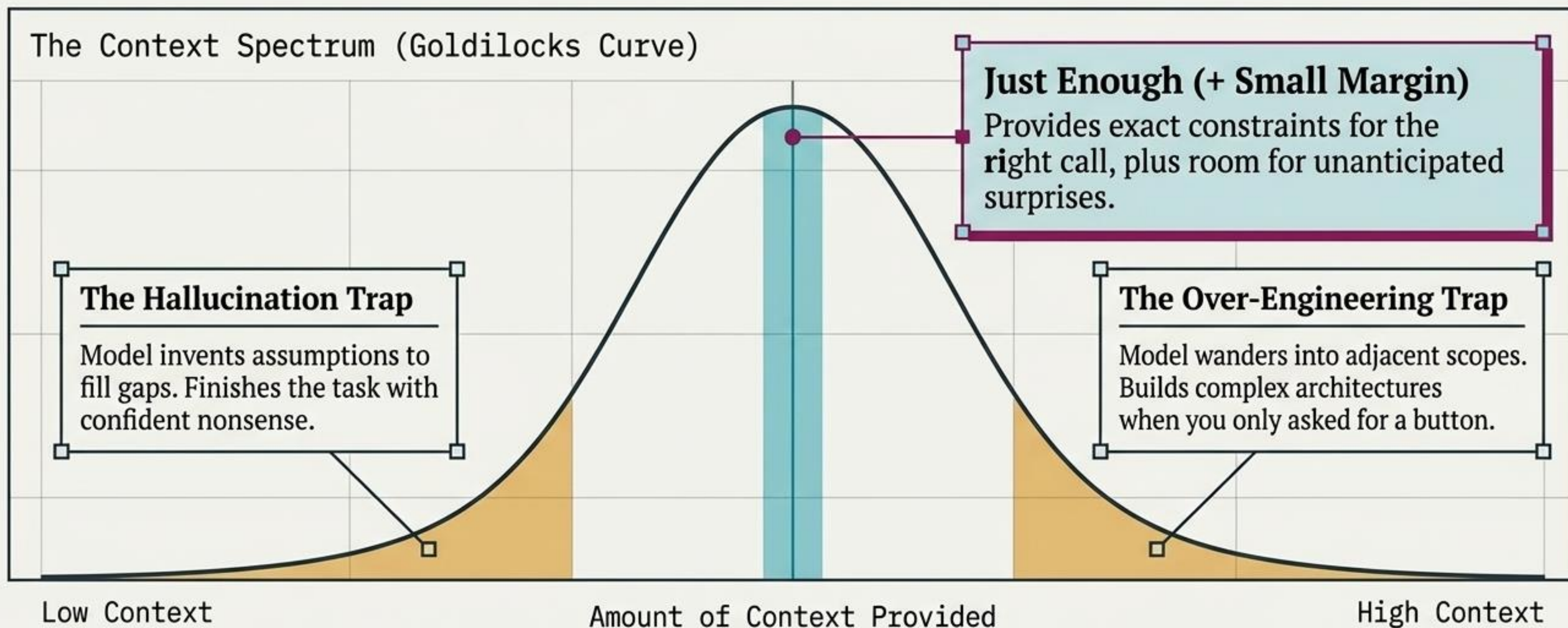


reports: LLMs

primary_work: briefing, directing, reviewing

The Actual Work: Reaching for old instincts. The failures rhyme, and the old mechanics still land perfectly.

The Context Spectrum dictates the success of your brief.



When the brief is bad, the failure belongs to the person who wrote it.

Stop searching for a single winner. Draft a balanced roster.

The Roster Comparison Matrix

Claude

The Fast, Arrogant Dev

✧ Strengths

Peak intelligence, sharp design.

⚠ Weaknesses

Lazy token limit (stops after a 6-hour day), poor web crawling.

🏛 Deployment

Where speed is worth more than caution.

ChatGPT

The Dependable Middle

✧ Strengths

Balanced reasoning, acceptable token price, capable web crawl.

⚠ Weaknesses

Not peak raw intelligence.

🏛 Deployment

Quietly carrying a third of the sprint without bottlenecking.

Gemini

The Specialist Researcher

✧ Strengths

Elite web crawling (Google origins).

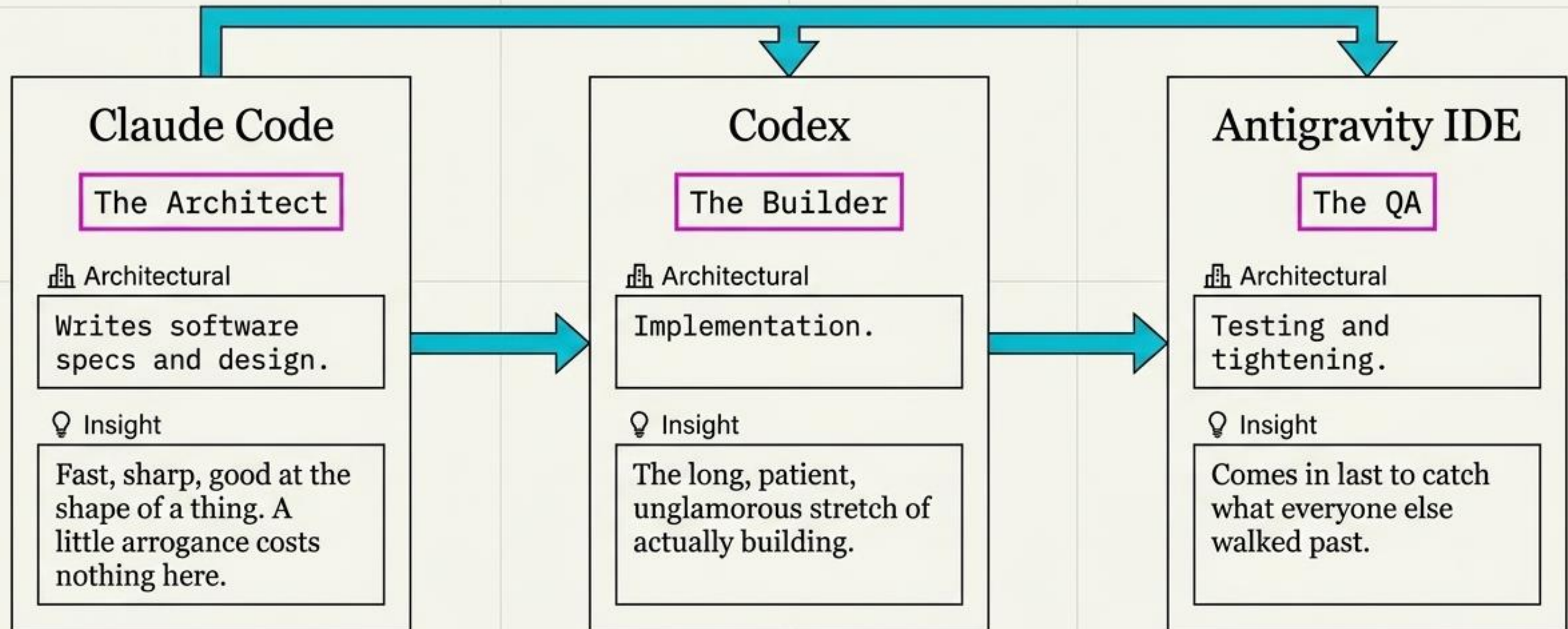
⚠ Weaknesses

Struggles with complex logic reasoning.

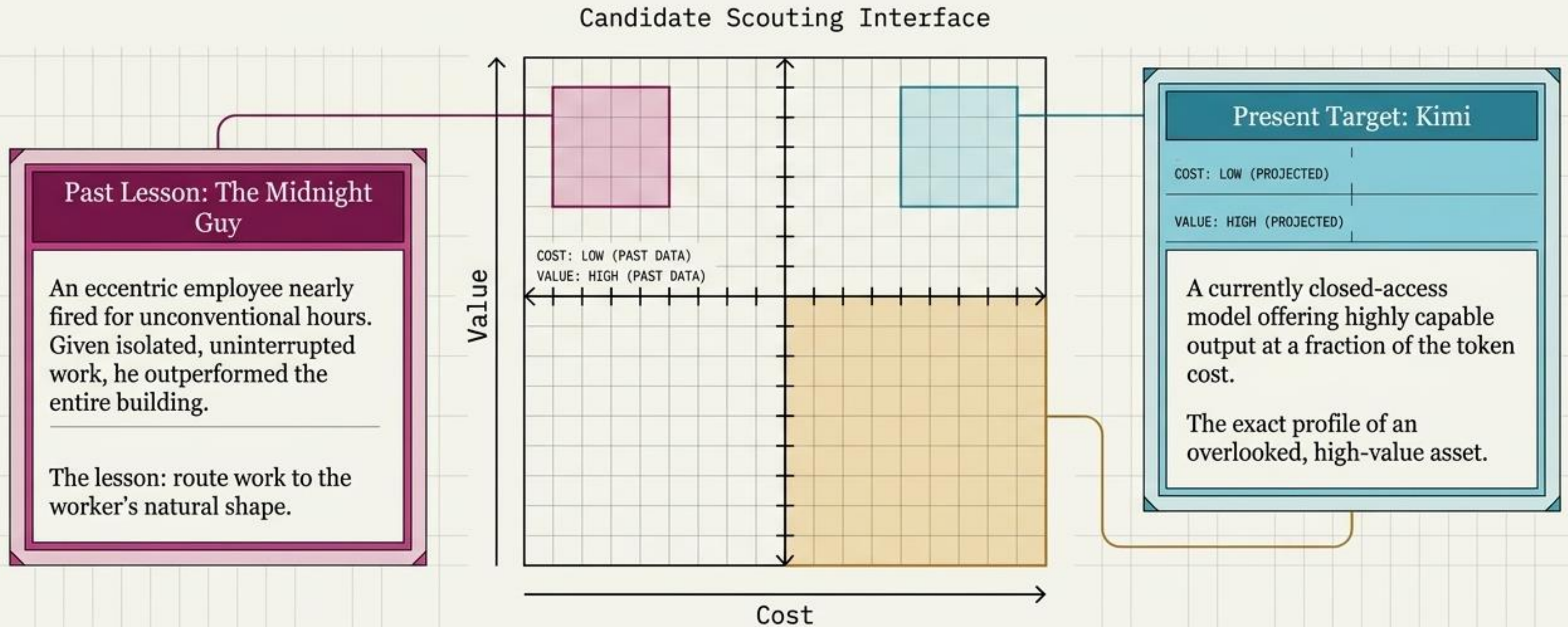
🏛 Deployment

Pure research and data synthesis.

Staff your tools precisely to match the grain of the work.



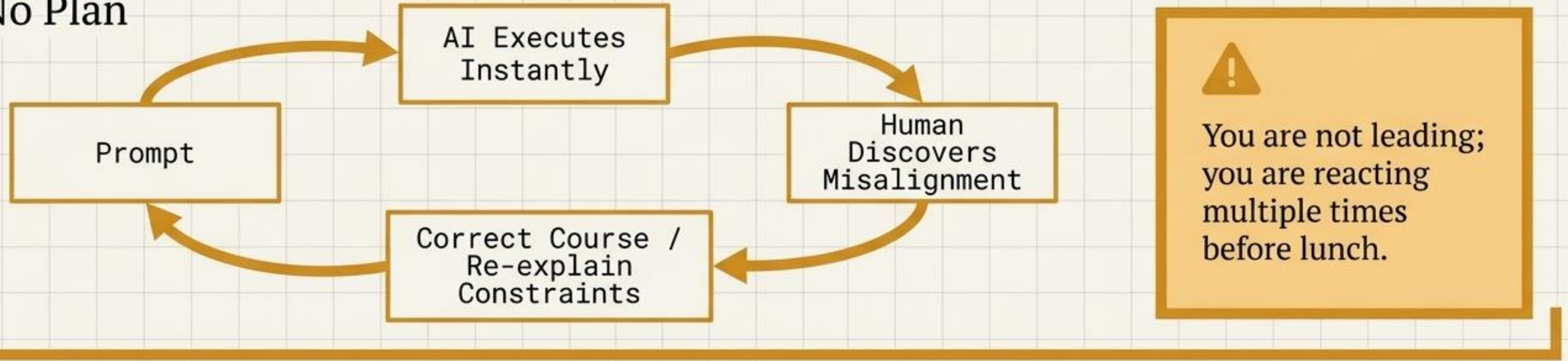
Never accept a good-enough roster.



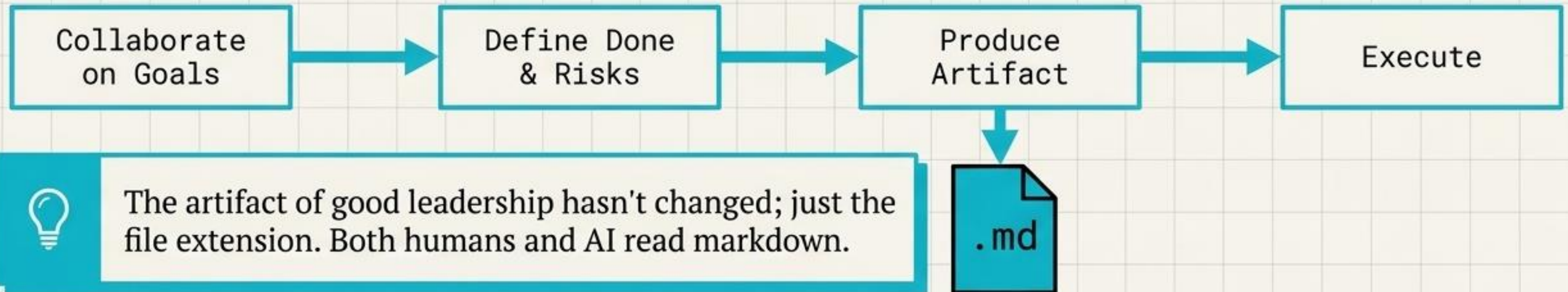
Takeaway: Always keep the door open to see what a new asset is actually good at.

Foregoing a plan forces you into a chaotic chasing loop.

No Plan

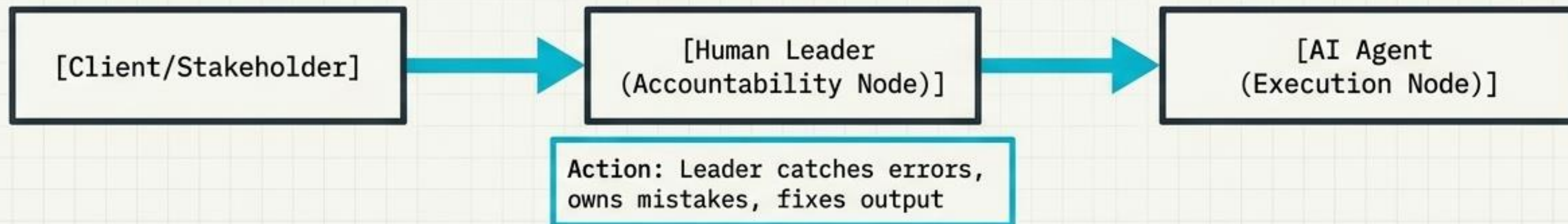


The Plan

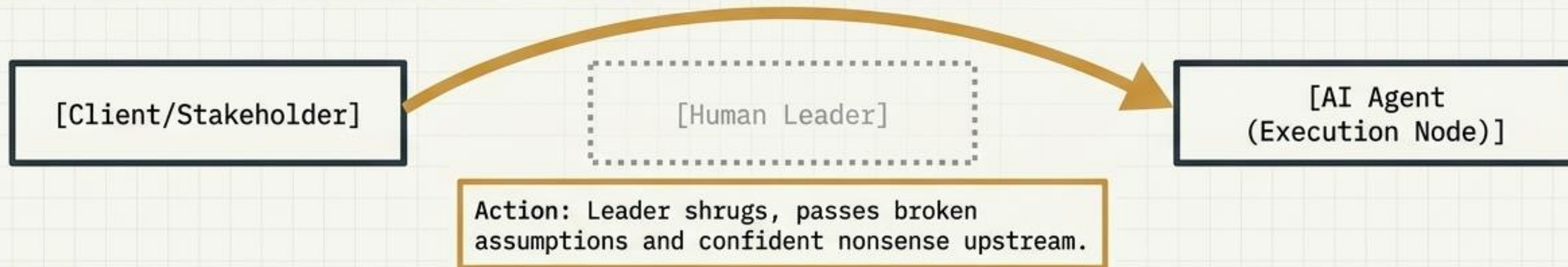


The Pass-Through Trap: Why 'The AI did it' is a career killer

State 1: The Valuable Leader

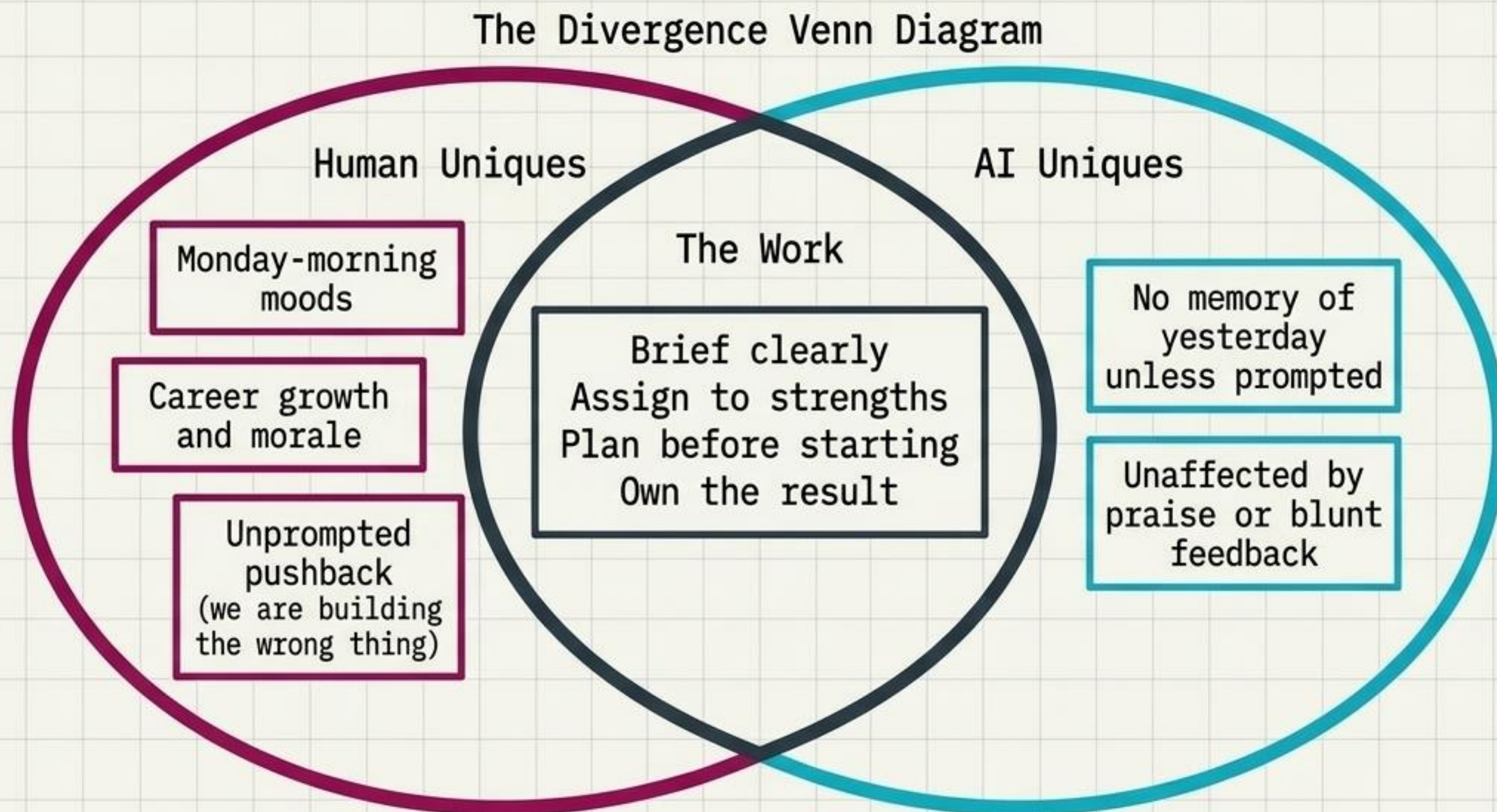


State 2: The Pass-Through - Warning State ⚠



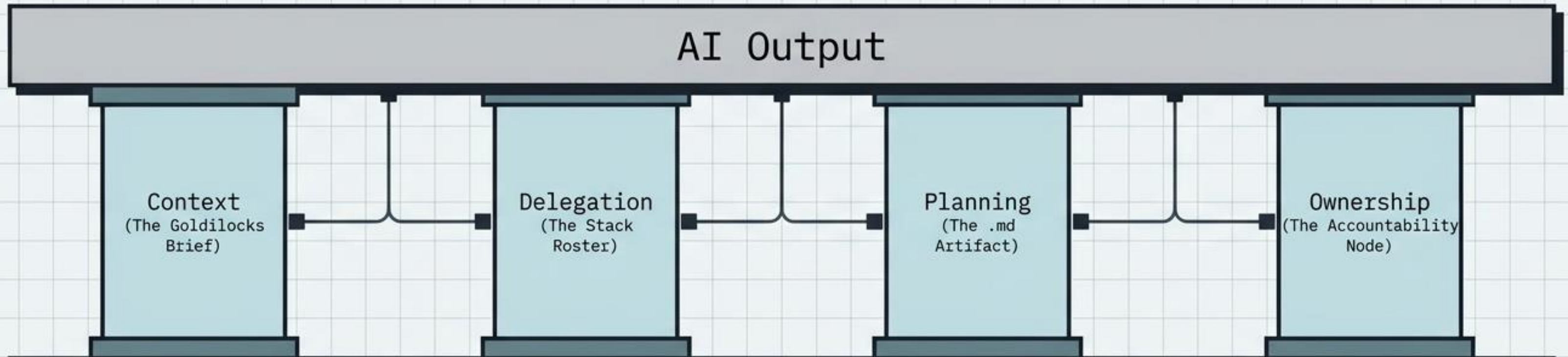
If you take no responsibility for the result, why employ you? The token price is cheaper than your salary. Extreme ownership is the specific concrete thing you are paid for.

Where the analogy breaks down: The Relationship vs. The Work.



The parts that changed are human. The parts that fill your calendar are operational.

Human skill is not deprecated. It is load-bearing.



The industry predicted that technical execution was safe while human management would become decoration. The exact opposite occurred. The tools changed completely. The job of directing them barely changed at all.